

RUTABAGAS *Brassica napus* Napobrassica Group

Known as “Swedish turnips” or “Swedes” in England, turnips or “neeps” in Scotland, and rutabagas in the United States, rutabagas are a staple of many soups, stews, and casseroles. Their sweet orange or yellow flesh is also delicious mashed. This very hardy root vegetable is actually a member of the brassica family and is well worth growing, despite its slow growth and the number of pests and diseases that can affect crops.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW/PLANT				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Prepare your plot the previous fall by digging in well-rotted manure or compost. Rutabagas like a sunny position in a light soil with a pH above 6.8. Relatively slow-growing, they can take up to six months before they are ready to harvest, so sow as soon as the soil has warmed up, and protect with fleece, cold frames, or cloches if the weather turns cold.

Sow in pots and transplant or sow directly into shallow drills that are .75 in (2 cm) deep, and at least 15 in (38 cm) apart. Once the seedlings have established, thin to about 9 in (23 cm) apart.

CROP CARE

Weed and water regularly and be vigilant against pests.



Cut away the leafy stems before storing.

HARVESTING

Rutabagas should be ready to harvest in fall or early winter when they are about 4–6 in (10–15 cm) in diameter. They can be left in the ground for as long as needed, even over winter, although bear in mind that the longer they are left, the greater the risk that they will turn woody and will need a protective layer of straw if the weather turns cold.